locked on the *Motobu*.[33] The captain of the thousand-ton Japanese patrol ship, knowing he could not survive a direct hit from the PLAN destroyer, radioed repeated demands that the radar be turned off. When no Chinese response was forthcoming, and with rescue operations ongoing, the *Motobu*'s commander fired one round from his Bushmaster II 30 mm chain gun across the bow of the *Taiyuan*. In response, a nearby Chinese frigate, thinking it was under attack from the Japanese Coast Guard ship, fired a torpedo in the direction of the *Motobu*. In the congested seas, however, the torpedo hit the *Charleston*, which was transiting between the Chinese and Japanese ships, ripping a hole below the waterline. The lightly armored littoral combat ship, with a complement of fifty officers and seamen, foundered in just twenty-five minutes, with an unknown loss of life, at 01:30 (17:30 Greenwich time; 07:30 Hawaii time; 10:30 eastern time) on Tuesday, September 9.[34] US surveillance drones flying over the melee recorded parts of the encounter and flashed images back to US commanders in the region.

IV. The Choice for War: September 9–23, 2025

When word of the aerial and maritime encounters began filtering in to the USS *Blue Ridge*, flagship of the US Navy's Seventh Fleet, and US Pacific Fleet headquarters in Hawaii, rescue operations were immediately ordered. As the late-night and early-morning melee developed, US commanders watched in near real time as the *Charleston* sank. Within ten minutes, the *Curtis Wilbur* was ordered to leave the site of the downed EP-3 and instead move to pick up all US survivors from the two lost ships. Within twenty minutes, the four-star admiral in command of US Indo-Pacific Command had directed the commander of the US Pacific Fleet to order the *Gerald Ford* to steam to the location, provide rescue operations, and protect all US and allied ships in the South China Sea area. Over the previous decade, as Chinese naval and missile capabilities increased, it became a working assumption that US